theatre, either cannot be stabilised easily or that it will be stabilised on the basis of Chinese hegemony:

> The choice for Asia is between power balanced at the price of conflict or peace secured at the price of hegemony. Western societies might go for conflict and balance. History, culture, and the realities of power strongly suggest that Asia will opt for peace and hegemony. … China is resuming its place as regional hegemon, and the East is coming into its own.[79]

Huntington startlingly assumed that Asians are markedly different from Europeans in terms of political culture. His assumption that Asians are prone to supine behaviour might have come from the ease with which Europeans established control over much of Asia in the age of imperialism. It was really the triumph of technology, sea power, and the superior conduct of war that gave Europeans relatively easy victories in Asia. The Battle of Plassey and the Treaty of Nanking were the results of these advantages, not of supineness on the part of Indians or Chinese. Japanese militarism and Chinese, Vietnamese, and Afghan resistance do not square up with Huntington's formulation.

Like the United States, India too is in a permanent state of competition with China, but neither country desires confrontation with China. The leadership of both India and the United States are aware that economic transformation could drive China towards pre-eminence, first in Asia, then in the world. There is, however, one critical difference between how India and the United States approach China. India is an immediate neighbour of China and therefore shares with it many common challenges but also an inheritance of a war and disputed borders. The United States, while a *de facto* Asian power (given its Asian allies, friends, and military deployments) is itself geographically farther away. There is a vast and deep ocean separating China and the United States,